only a handful, and these were [Photo Interpreters], knew exactly what it was they were looking at … Never have so many taken so much on the say so of so few.'[8]

While history records with approval Adlai Stevenson's willingness to wait until hell froze over, the rest of world was increasingly worried that time was running out. 'The trial of wills is now approaching a climax,' Macmillan wrote to Kennedy as the world held its breath.[9] In fact, and, of course wholly unbeknownst to Kennedy or Macmillan, the trial was already reaching its verdict. In 2003 fragmentary records of key meetings of the Presidium became available. In 2006 Fursenko and Naftali published *Khrushchev's Cold War,* which expanded and revised their earlier book, *'One Hell of a Gamble*. The records of the Presidium meeting on Thursday, 25 October show that Khrushchev had already concluded that withdrawal of the missiles was necessary. This was before the crisis reached its public climax at the weekend.

Khrushchev felt the threat of an American attack on Cuba was growing. He invoked a scatological proverb about a man who goes on his first bear hunt with a wooden knife (to make cleaning his soiled trousers easier). With consummate hypocrisy, Khrushchev told his presumably bemused comrades that Kennedy was a coward, who 'had slept with a wooden knife'. [10] Yet it was Khrushchev who now sounded the retreat. In return for guarantees of Cuba's security, 'we must dismantle the missiles to create a zone of peace in Cuba'. The Presidium agreed. The decision was unanimous. Khrushchev's anxiety nevertheless increased over the next few days, though he remained keen to turn retreat into something he could call victory. He was a man in search of a golden bridge.

Doing lunch

The first indications in Washington that a deal could be struck came during Friday, 26 October. Although the meeting of the UN Security Council had proved a resounding political success for Washington, it had unsurprisingly failed to break the diplomatic impasse. The UN Secretary General,